CHRONOLOGY & CATASTROPHISM

REVIEW 2021:2

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BOOK REVIEW: ***Catastrophic Thinking: Extinction and the Value of Diversity from Darwin to the Anthropocene***

Plus **SOCIETY NEWS and LETTERS**

The North Portico of Knossos, Crete. The restored fresco of a charging bull can be seen between the pillars. Knossos was the major site of the Minoan Civilisation of Crete, and was one of the largest ancient cities of the Bronze Age. (photo: Karl-Heinz Lewin)

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Linear A is deciphered – its Language is Greek

Karl-Heinz Lewin

Introduction

A Ukrainian linguist may have achieved a minor sensation - the decipherment of Linear A under the assumption that, like Linear B, the texts are written in the Greek language.

The Linguist Iurii Mosenkis

Iurii Leonidovich Mosenkis is a professor at the Institute of Philology of Kyiv University, in the Department of Ukrainian Language and Applied Linguistics. His scientific interests include, in particular, the evolution of languages and comparative linguistics [1].

In recent years he published on the Academia.edu website more than 260 papers ranging from notes to elaborated documents to a book (all except the book [2], unfortunately, without specification of a publication year). Among the languages he studied and partially compared are Ukrainian, the Slavic and Baltoslavic languages, (Ancient) Greek, Pelasgic, Phrygian, Proto-Arian, Italic, Umbrian, Old Irish, Celtic, Proto-Indo-European, Georgian/Kartvelic, Daghestan, Hurro-Urartian, Sumerian, Hattic, Kassitic, Guanche, Basque, Etruscan, Burushaski, Dravidian, Altaic, Uralic, Yenisean, Ainu. In addition, his interests were focused on archaeology, especially of the Cucuteni-Trypillia culture, genetics as a means of determining lineages, the origins of fairy tales and myths, and astronomy as a means of retrocalculated chronological placement of events.

Remarks on the Linear Scripts of Crete

Cretan hieroglyphs were influenced by Egyptian hieroglyphs. Arthur Evans showed clear evidence of the Egyptian origin of several Cretan hieroglyphic characters, and Vladimir Ivanov Georgiev identified traces of their translation from Egyptian into Greek. The absence of the l/r distinction in Linear A and B is a typical feature of Egyptian writing [3].

The two Linear scripts are, in contrast to the Cretan hieroglyphic script, syllabic scripts, supplemented by number signs and more (Linear A) or less (Linear B) additional word signs. There are only open syllables with which words of the form CVCV and longer can be formed (C = consonant, V = vowel). Such words are found in Old Macedonian, Luwian, Akkadian, and Dravidian languages, as well as in a pre-Sumeric substrate [4]. Semitic languages such as Arabic and Hebrew have frequent words in the forms CVCVC and VCCVC. Ancient Greek, on the other hand, is characterized by frequent multiple consonants (like German). The best-known example is the Greek word ανθροπος / *anthropos*, which was approximated in Linear B as *a-to-ro-po*.

> Linear B does not consistently distinguish between voiced and voiceless plosives (except in the dental series) and between aspirated and unaspirated stops even when these distinctions are phonemic in Mycenaean Greek. [5]
>
> (KA/KHA/GA are written with *ka* and PA/PHA/BA with *pa*). Only for the voiced dental D there is a separate set of syllable signs, so that DA is written with *da* and TA/THA with *ta*. [6]

This distinction (voiceless/aspirated/voiceless) is typical of the Indo-European languages, thus also of ancient Greek, but also of the Semitic languages; the absence of this distinction, on the other hand, is found in the Hurrian-Urartian languages and the Eteocyprian and Cypriot-Minoan languages, which may be related to them or at least influenced by them [7].

Therefore, the Cretan linear scripts are conceivably unsuitable for the rendering of an Indo-European language such as ancient Greek, but hardly less suitable for the rendering of a presumed Semitic language.

A particular difficulty also lies in distinguishing between phonetic peculiarities of the "Minoan dialect" of whatever language and the orthographic rules of Linear A/B enforced by the available syllable supply [8]. For example, the final -*se*, common in classical Cypriot syllabary, is absent in Linear B (although a syllabic *se* exists). This was considered an 'argument' against the Greek language of Linear B. The final -*o*, typical in Linear B, is again absent in Linear A - which is now considered an 'argument' against the Greek language of Linear A [9].

Moreover, the syllable inventories are not complete - not all combinations of the consonants *d j k r m n p q r s t w z* with the vowels *a e i o u* occur. In Linear B a few syllables on -*i* and -*u* are missing (up to now?), in Linear A the syllables on -*e* and especially -*o* are incomplete - *do*, *jo*, *mo*, *no*, *qo*, *so*, *wo* are missing [10].

The Language of Linear A - the Hypotheses

Evans considered the Minoan and Mycenaean civilizations both non-Greek, although he had read a Greek word in Linear B: using classical Cypriot syllabic writing, the scholar read the word *po-lo* = πῶλος / *pōlos*, "foal," written near horse imagery on a Linear B tablet. Michael Ventris' decipherment confirmed the hypothesis of Paul Kretschmer, S. Luria, and V. Georgiev that Linear B (15th-13th century B.C.) – and thus Mycenaean culture – was Greek, while earlier Cretan hieroglyphs, the Phaistos Disc, Linear A, and later Eteocretan inscriptions are considered undeciphered [11].

As early as 1950, two years before the publication of the decipherment of Linear B, but perhaps aware of Ventris' work, Georgiev had published his conjecture, supported by several word equations, that Linear A represented the Greek language or a Greek dialect [12]. Especially because of the continuously used open syllables and the lack of distinctions b/p/ph, g/k/kh and t/th (see above), other researchers looked for words from other languages and found Semitic and Luwian words. The main proponent of the hypothesis that the language of Linear A was a Semitic one became Cyrus Herzl Gordon [13], although closed syllables also predominate in Semitic languages and the distinction of the three classes of closing sounds often bears meaning. The Hittite-Luwian hypothesis was first advanced by Leonard Robert Palmer [14]. The argument that the words now read as Greek are probably loanwords could equally apply to the words read as Semitic as well as to those read as Luwian.

Subsequently, there was no lack of attempts to find either further Semitic or Luwian or Greek words in Linear A. Maurice Pope wrote about this in 1958: "For Minoan to contain some Semitic words would not be surprising. Bronze Age Crete belonged to the same culture as the contemporary Near East. It is natural that technical terms of accountancy and of articles of commerce such as pots should have been borrowed. [15]" He considered it conceivable that "Minoan" was a Semitic language, but proof was "still" a long way off - the "clearest piece of evidence" was the legend that Minos was a grandson of Phoinix, king of Tyre [16]. In contrast, for him it was certain: "The only Minoan word whose meaning is certainly known is *kuro* or *kulo* = «total». There is no doubt that this could be Semitic (Akkadian *kalu*, *kullatu*; Hebrew *kôl*; etc.). [17]"

Relationships with languages such as Abkhaz-Adyghic, Etruscan, Hurrian, Indo-Iranian and Lycian, as well as a lost branch of Indo-European and an unknown language family, were also discussed but did not find recognition [18].

Strong arguments for a Greek language were found by Gregory Nagy, who identified many place names and other words written the same or almost the same in Linear A and Linear B and considerably expanded the Greek word list in Linear A [19]. Nagy identified the Linear A words *pa-i-to* = Linear B *pa-i-to* = Φαιστός / *Phaistós*, Linear A *qe-tu* = Linear B *qe-to* = πίθοι / *pithoi*, Linear A *i-ta-nu* = Linear B *u-ta-no* = Ἴτανος / *Itanos* (Cretan city), *i-ja-te* = ιατηρ / *iatēr*, "doctor", *ki-ro* = χρέος, χρή / *chreos*, *chrē*, "debt", "need", *ka-pa* = καρποι / *karpoi*, "fruits", *ma-ka-ri-te* = Μακαρίτης / *Makarítēs*, "the blessed", *ka* = καί / *kaí*, "and", Linear A *wo-no* = Linear B *wo-no* = (ϝ)οῖνος / *(w)oinos*, "wine", the suffixes Linear A *-qe* = Linear B *-qe* = -τε / *-te* (= Lat. *-que*) and morphological elements as in the juxtaposition of "Linear A *su-ki-ri-ta* = Linear B *su-ki-ri-ta* = Σύβριτα / *Sygrita* (Cretan town)" to Linear A "*su-ki-ri-te-i-ja* ≈ Linear B *su-ki-ri-ta-jo* = *Sugritajos*" (ethnic assignment, roughly "inhabitant(s) of Sygrita") [20]. There are numerous equivalents to the latter example in Linear B [21].

> Why the voice of G. Nagy was not heard – it is an enigma for me. In contrast, the voice of M. Ventris was heard very quickly despite the fact that his Greek reading of Linear B contrasted with a half-century tradition. [22]

Instead, many other "decipherers" "read" individual words on vases and "found" them in Akkadian, Lycian or Luwian texts, but this did not prove that Linear A belonged to the respective language (John Chadwick according to Jean-Pierre Olivier) [23].

Methods for Deciding between Conceivable Solutions

Statistical method: How often do selected syllable groups occur in the script to be deciphered, and which syllable groups can be found with corresponding frequencies in the target languages available for selection? Alice Kober and Michael Ventris used statistics to decipher Linear B. However, the available corpus of inscriptions in Linear A is so small, estimated at about six to seven book pages, that one does not get far with statistics, although significant statistical observations have been published [24].

Combinatorial method: If words or word forms frequently occur together and show variations (affixes, here mostly suffixes), how can these be connected with the corresponding forms in one of the target languages? Can frequent word combinations or word juxtapositions or morphological elements be deduced from this? This method leads further here [25]:

Example 1: The words *ku-ro* and *ki-ro* were found several times in context and identified as "sum" and "debt". They are very similar to two Greek words, κόρος / *kóros*, "satiety, surfeit" and χρέος / *chréos*, "debt". Correspondingly, *ku-ra* then fits κυρία / *kyría*, "authority, power" and κύρια / *kýria*, "the powerful one" (*fem.*).

Example 2: The word *po-to-ku-ro* seems to be related to *ku-ro*. Georgiev in 1958 compared the front part with Tocharian A, B *ponto*, "all", but παντακύριος / *pantakýrios*, "surpassing all" is a much closer equivalent. This gives Linear A *po-to-ku-ro* = "all together, total sum" [26].

Example 3: With this method, some morphological elements in Linear A were recognised: the distinction *i-ja-te* "doctor" and *i-ja-ma* "medicine", the connective *-qe* (corresponding to Latin *-que*), the feminine adjective suffix *-ja*, the dative ending *-si*, the mediopassive participle suffix *-men*; for further examples see below.

Quasi-bilingual methods: a word on an object can denote it or one of its properties [27]: *tu-nu* on an axe could mean θύνω / *thýnō*, "rush, dart along", *da-ku* on another axe θάγω / *thagō*, "sharpen, whet" or θηγός / thēgos, "sharp", *e-si-ja* on a lamp ἑστία / *hestía*, "hearth", *u-na-a* on a pithos-like vessel *οἰναία / *(inferred) oinaia*, "wine vessel".

Cretan proper names from Linear B and alphabetic Greek may also provide clues here (just as proper names were the first identified words in Egyptian hieroglyphics or in Linear B) [28]:

Linear A	Linear B	Modern
ka-nu-ti	*ko-no-si*	Knossos
pa-i-to	*pa-i-to*	Phaistos
da-ri-da	*ti-ri-to*	Tritos

Etymological method [29]: This had a bad reputation among critics of decipherment attempts, but could provide some important information, for example: Linear A *ma-te-re* = Linear B *ma-te-re* = Gr. *matrei*, "to the mother" (*dative*); Linear A *da-ma-te* = Δαμάτηρ, Demeter, according to Homer from Crete; Linear A *a-ra-u-da*, Linear B *e-re-u-ti-ja*, Doric Ἐλεύθυια / Eleúthyia, ancient Gr. Εἰλείθυια / *Eíleíthyia*, "the one who comes (to help)", the goddess of childbirth [30], known from the Odyssey and from Pausanias, who was especially worshipped in the Eleuthyia cave near Amnissos on Crete.

Further Evidence for the Greek Language of the Minoan Culture

The monster Scylla (Σκύλλη) is depicted by Minoan painters with a dog's head, recalling the Greek word for "whelp, puppy", σκύλαξ / *skylax* (Fig. 1) [31]. Minoan images of knots were reminiscent of the Egyptian life sign Ankh, whose name resembles the Greek word ἄγχω / *ángkho* ("squeeze") (Fig. 2) [32] The syllabic sign derived from it has the phonetic value *za*, corresponding to the Greek word ζαω / *zaô* ("to live") [33]. The Minoan calendar painting contained the signs for solstices and equinoxes (τροπή / *tropē*, "the turn"), which were represented as ships (τροπίς / *tropís*, "keel" and "ship"), thus reflecting Greek homonymy (Fig. 3) [34]. Conclusion: "*Minoan painters were Greek-spoken*" [35], and they also knew at least individual Egyptian terms and their Egyptian designations.

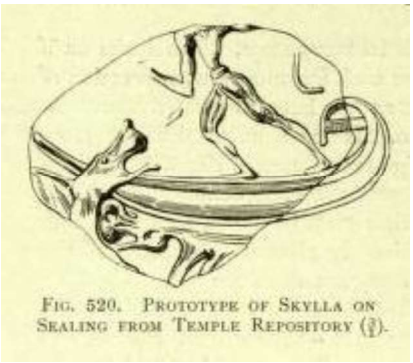

Fig. 1

Fig. 2

Fig. 3

With *ki-ro* = χρέος, χρή / *chreos*, "debt" (see above) and *ku-ro* / *ku-ra* ("sum") = κυριός / *kyriós* ("whole", "complete") and κυρία / *kyría* ("possession") respectively, two central terms from accounting and administration are represented by Greek words [36]. Of all things, a word that Pope at the time judged to be Semitic (see above) now serves Mosenkis as important evidence for the Greek language of Linear A! Another weighty word is *ma-te* for "mother", while the Anatolian languages (Hittite, Luwian) have *anna* for this [37], the Semitic *umm* or *ēm* or similar.

Cretan hieroglyphic writing consists not only of logograms, but also contains phonetic (syllabic) signs [38]. Many of these can be "read" thanks to their similarities with signs of the two linear scripts; the readings suggest that they represent a Greek dialect, with some words having similarities to Phrygian sounds [39]. Some syllabic signs of the Cretan hieroglyphs as well as of the linear scripts seem to be abbreviations on the first syllable of the Greek names of the depicted objects, such as *za* of ζαω (see above); the Cretan hieroglyph *PLOUGH* as the archetype of the Linear A/B syllable sign *u* corresponds to the initial syllable of ὕνις / *hynis* ("ploughshare"); the Egyptian hieroglyph *kebeh*, "jug" resembles the syllable sign *ki*, the initial syllable of Gr. *kissubion*; the Egyptian hieroglyph *aha*, "palace" resembles the syllable *wa*, the initial syllable of Gr. *wanakterion* [40].

Therefore, some Cretan hieroglyphic inscriptions can be read in Greek: for example, the hieroglyph *KNEE* as γόνυ / *góny*, *genitive* γόνατος / *gónatos* and thus as a homonym for Linear A *ka-nu-ti* = Linear B *ko-no-si* (Knossos) corresponding to γνοστος / *gnostos* ("the best known", "the famous"), the hieroglyph *KNEE* with the syllable mark *ja* as an adjective suffix would correspond to the phonation *gonat-ja* = Linear A *ka-nu-ti-ja* = Linear B *ko-no-si-ja* = Κνωσία / knossia (*feminine* "the one from Knossos", "the Knossian"). Also, the hieroglyphic image of a dog (κυον / *kyon*) or wolf (κνακιας / *knakias*) could perhaps be read as a reference to Knossos, unless the wolf stood for γυναικ- / *gynaik-* ("woman"). Finally, the hieroglyph *SPIDER* (αραχνα / *arakhna*) can be read as Linear A/B *A-ri-hag-na* = Greek Ariadne [41]; the Cretan hieroglyphic inscription *wa-nwa* can be compared with Linear A *u-na-ka*, Linear B *wa-na-ka* and interpreted as the same

title ("king") in three scripts [42]. Furthermore, the spelling *si-FIG-ka* (hieroglyph *FIG* surrounded by two syllabic signs) corresponds to σῦκα / *syka*, "figs" [43].

The oldest signs of Cretan hieroglyphs were found at Archanes and date to the Middle Minoan I phase – according to the "high" chronologies from 2160/2050/2000 BC, according to the "low" chronologies from 2000/1979/1900 BCE (conventionally) [44]. This would give the Greek language the oldest writing system of all Indo-European languages [45], several centuries older than the Hittite-Luwian scripts [46].

Specific Problems of Distinction between Greek Phonetics and Linear A Orthography

The more word equations between Linear A and Ancient Greek are recognised, the more unexpected spellings emerge: *u* for *o* or even *e*, as in *u-na-ru-ka-na-ti/si* ≈ ἐναρξάντι/σι / *enarxánti/si*; *i* for *ē*, as in *a-si-ki-ra* for ἀσκηρά / *askērá*; *d* stands for θ as in *di-ri-na* ≈ θρινία / *thrinía* or for δ as in *ro-da* ≈ Ῥόδια / *Rhódia*, sometimes *t* stands for θ as in *ki-re-ta2* = Linear B *ki-ri-ta* = κριθή / *krithē*; *j* sometimes stands for *h* as in *i-ru-ja* /eluha/ < ἔλυσα / *élysa* - the Linear A/B syllabic *ja* /ha/ gave rise to the Phoenician *het* (though not until a millennium after Linear A – possibly an indication of inconsistent conventional chronology!), which became the Greek H; *q* in Linear B corresponds to the labiovelar *qu* (cf. *-qe* = Lat. *-que*), but in Linear A not infrequently also χ as in *a-se-tu-qi* ≈ ἀστυ-όχη / *astyóchē*, *qa-ti-ju* ≈ *Χαττιοί / *(inferred) Khattioí* < Hatti, Homeric Κήτειοι / *Kēteioi*; *w* stands for ϝ as in *wi-pi* ≈ ϝίφι / *wiphi* or for the labiovelar *gw* as in *wa-pi-ti-na(*te)-ra2* on a pithos ≈ βαπτιστήριον / *baptistērion* < **guap-*; *z* reflects *z* < *dj* as in *ki-re-za* ≈ κράδη / *krádē* or *z* < *gj* as in *ma-za* ≈ μᾶζα / *mãza* or *z* < *kj* as in *du-re-za-se* = Linear B *de-re-u-ko* ≈ δλυκύς / *dlykýs* or *g* as in *a-zu-ra* ≈ ἀγορά / *agorá*; on the other hand also *s* > *g* as in *ma-si-du* ≈ μαγίδιον / *magídion*, so there are no universal rules [47].

Examples of Greek morphology in Linear A [48]

Linear A	Griechisch	English
i-ja-ma	ιαμα / *iama*	remedy, medicine
i-ja-te	ιατηρ / *iatēr*	healer, pysician
a-ki-ro	ἄχρεος / *áchreos*	useless, futile
a-da-ro	ἄδωρα / *adōra*	ungifted *or* undonated
suffix *-ja*	-ία / *-ia*	*feminine adjective suffix*
si-da-te	σιτευτός / *siteutós*	fattened
prefix *a-*: *a-si-da-to-i*	*ἀσιτευτόι / **asiteutói (erschlossen)*	unfed *(pl.)*
or: *si-da-te*	συνδέτης / *syndétēs*	one who holds together
prefix *a-*: *a-si-da-to-i*	ἀσύνδετοι / *asýndetoi*	unconnected *(pl.)*
or [MI a, 19]: *si-da-te*	συνθέτη / *synthétē*	composed
prefix *a-*: *a-si-da-to-i*	ἀσύνθετοι / *asýnthetoi*	uncomposed *(pl.)*

"These grammatical forms of Indo-European origin might be the strongest proof of the Greek language of Linear A, in contrast to lexical elements which might have been borrowed." [49]

Grammar

Due to the limited corpus of inscriptions, the available examples are sparse but obviously well in accordance with Greek forms [50]:

1. Morphology of the nouns:
   a) The word-forming suffixes *-ma* and *–tēr* of Indo-European origin in the examples Linear A *i-ja-ma* = ιαμα / *iama*, "remedy", "medicine"; Linear A *i-ja-te* = ιατηρ / *iatēr*, "healer", "physician"
   b) The typical Greek negation prefix *a-*: Linear A *a-si-su-po-a*, "not very clear", cf. Σίσυφος / Sísyphos, literally "very clever"; Linear A *a-su-pu-wa*, "(vessel) without a spout", cfl. συπύη / *sypýē*, "food tub", or "(big) bowl"; further examples from [51]: Linear A *a-ki-ro*, ἄχρεος / *áchreos*, "useless", "futile"; Linear A *a-da-ro*, ἄδωρα / *adōra*, "ungifted" or "undonated"
   c) Typical Greek Suffixes for Nomina Agentis: Linear A *ma-ti-za-i-te*, *μαστιγ-αίτης / **mastigaítēs*, "coach man"; Linear A *ma-te-ti*, ματευτής / *mateutēs*, "seeker, searcher"; Linear A *ma-ka-i-ta*, Aeolian μαχαίτας / *machaítas*, "fighter, warrior"

d) Prefixes: Linear A *a-pa*, ἀπο / *apo*, "from ... away"; but in an example which is not clear to me

2. Declension of the nouns:
   Genitive sg. m.: (from Italy) *ku-ra-tu-jo*, Κρατοῖο / *Kratoĩo*, Gen. of Κρατύς / *Kratýs* (probably a name).

   Genitive sg. f.: (on a lamp) *i-ja-re-wi-ja*, ἰαρηϝίjας / *íarēwijas*, "of the priestess" or "of the sanctuary".

   Dative sg. f.: *ja-su-ma-tu OLIVE*, αἰσυμνητύι / *aísymnētýi*, olives for the αἰσυμνητύς / *aísymnētýs* (whatever the latter word may mean)

   Acc. sg. m.: (from Italy) *i-ja*, υἷα / *yĩa*, the son.

   Nom. pl. m.: *si-da-te – a-si-da-to-i*, συνθέτη / *synthétē* – ἀσύνθετοι / *asýnthetoi* "composed ones" – "not composed ones"; also *ku-re-ju*, χορεῖοι / *choreĩoi*, "members of the choir".

   Nom. pl. f.: *di-ki-se*, θίξεις / thixeis, "the touching, those who touch" (*fem. Pl.*).

3. Pronouns:
   Pronouns are extremely rare in Linear A:

   Linear A (on a pin) *wi-te-ja-mu*, (ϝ)ἴδια μου οἴκετις / *(w)ídia mou oíketis*, "my own housewife (a slave?)", literally: "own of mine" (*Gen. 1. P. sg. f.*) (the form ίδια μου („my own" *sg. f.*) is still used in the same way in Modern Greek).

   Linear A *i-da-mi*, Linear B *–mi*, μιν / *min*, she (Acc. sg.)

4. Numerals:
   Numerical values are mostly represented by numbers in Linear A, their syllabic representation is very rare:

   Linear A *qe/ka-ti-ra-du MAN* (in front of *four* portions), τετράς, -άδος / *tetrás*, *-ádos*, vier, Phrygian *ke*, *Katreus*.

   Linear A *qe-pi-ta*, ἑπτά / *heptá*, "seven" in the context *da-qe-ra qe-pi-ta* (a title above *seven* personal names), *heptá dohelai*, "seven (female) slaves" (Linear B *do-e-ra*).

   Linear A *qa-sa-ra-ku*, *τεσσαράκονς (τεσσαράκοντα / *tessarákonta*, forty) or *τεσσαρακόηιοι (τεσσαρακόσιοι, four hundred). Alternatively: *exarchos*, leader

5. Conjugation:
   Present indicative active 1st P. sg.: *ka-ni-ja-mi*, ἐξανίημι / *exaníēmi*, I send out – in Linear B, on the other hand, verbs are only known in the 3rd person.

Mosenkis presents [52] a lot more examples of the extremely complex ancient Greek conjugation, function words such as the ending *–qe* (corresponding to Lat.. *–que*), word combinations and short texts as well as examples of Greek etymology, from which I will only pick out: Linear A *qe-ra$_2$-u* = Linear B *e-ra-wo* = *ἔλαιFον* / *élaiwon*, "olive oil", compared to Linear A *qe-ra$_2$-ja* = Linear. B *e-ra-wa* = *ἐλαίFα* / *elaíwa*, "olive tree", and finally Linear A *zu-wa* = Linear B *di-wo* = Zeus!

Many of his small discoveries, such as those about Minoan artists, Cretan agricultural products, morphology and grammar, or the quasi-bilinguals mentioned above, were first published by Mosenkis as notes, each in a short Word document, on the Academia.edu platform, before he compiled his findings into more extensive documents.

Conclusion

Mosenkis has provided the strongest argument so far that the language of Linear A is Greek, and is in a dialect similar to the ancient Macedonian dialects. [53] However, his arguments are not yet accepted by many linguists [54].

Notes and References

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